Words we can’t take back

Written by

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For Writer’s Room

The First Half

FINN
LUCAS
Carol
Shelby
JULIA
UNKNOWN

The Second Half (P.25)

TIM
TONY
DETECTIVE HARRIS
CHRIS ANDERSON

1 EXT. SUBURBAN NEIGHBORHOOD / DOWNTOWN - MORNING 1

LUCAS (20s) sprints down a sidewalk in a quiet residential area. His breath is ragged, forming quick puffs of steam in the chilly air.

LUCAS (V.O.)
I don’t have all the details, but the only reason I am running this fast, this early, is because of Pee-Pee Pasta. Okay, wait… let me start over. I’m running to my best friend Finn’s house because he called me—

Text: “Lucas, I need you here ASAP… Pee-Pee Pasta.”

Lucas cuts sharply across an empty downtown intersection. He dodges a newspaper stand.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
It acts like a special pass we can use, but he can’t seem to stop using it. It’s like an emergency button we only remember to use at the worst times. I don’t know where it comes from, but whenever it comes from Finn, I end up in deep shit. I shouldn’t be surprised, but it’s always something new. Every single time.

Lucas slows slightly, pressing a hand to his burning ribs. He's panting.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
I’m about two blocks away now, and I have absolutely no clue what could be going on. It’s still early, but I’m already panting, each breath hitting my lungs like a hammer. My sneakers slap against the pavement, the chilly winter air stinging my skin as I push myself faster.

His phone BUZZES relentlessly in his pocket. He doesn't break stride or look down.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
My phone buzzes in my pocket—probably Finn, but I don’t need to check it. Whatever’s going on, it’s not good. Last time this happened, I found him sitting on the toilet, staring at a cockroach.

(MORE)

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
And when I say, “on the toilet,” I mean he was standing on the lid fully clothed, backpack on his back, everything. As though the world hadn’t moved around him while I got there.

Lucas shakes his head quickly, trying to clear the absurd image. He forces himself to pick up the pace again.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
I shake my head, trying to get the image out of my mind, but it’s burned in there now... I mean, last time I had to drop everything for a “Pee Pee Pasta” emergency, it was because Finn had gotten involved with a British guy who turned out to be exploiting him. Extortion. A British guy.

Lucas approaches the last corner before Finn's street. The skeletal trees lining the curb are visible.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
As I approach the last corner before Finn’s block, I slow my pace, my mind racing with all the scenarios. The whole thing makes me uneasy. It’s too quiet this morning, too calm for what I’m used to with Finn. Normally, when I’m rushing to help him, it’s always a mess, some kind of chaotic storm...

Lucas turns the corner, jogging now. He studies the houses.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
My stomach turns. I know he’s in some kind of trouble, but I don’t know how bad he is. I take a deep breath as I approach his street. The neighborhood’s a little too empty, a little too cold.

2 EXT. FINN'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS 2

Lucas reaches the front porch of a large, aging house.

LUCAS (V.O.)
I reach the front porch and knock on the door.

Lucas RAISES HIS FIST and KNOCKS. Hard.

SOUND: The THUD of the knock is swallowed by the silence.

He KNOCKS again, harder, more urgent. Still nothing. He presses his ear to the wood, listening intently. His hand hovers over the door handle.

LUCAS
Finn?

His voice is low, choked. No response. Lucas slowly turns the knob. The door creaks open a few inches.

LUCAS (cont'd)
Finn?

Louder this time. Still silence. Lucas pushes the door open slightly and steps into the foyer.

3 INT. FINN'S HOUSE - FOYER - CONTINUOUS 3

Lucas moves cautiously down the hall, toward the living room.

LUCAS (V.O.)
My nerves growing with each step.

He stops at the threshold of the living room.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
I move cautiously toward the living room, and that’s when I see him.

FINN (20s) is sitting on the couch, body slouched. His eyes are staring blankly ahead, unblinking.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
He doesn’t even seem to notice me standing there. His face is pale, his hands limp in his lap. I can see the tension in his posture.

Lucas swallows, his throat dry. He takes a tentative step closer.

LUCAS
Finn?

Finn slowly blinks. He looks at Lucas, his gaze unfocused.

LUCAS (V.O.)
When his eyes land on me, they’re empty, haunted.

Lucas's gaze drops.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
And that’s when I see it—on the floor in front of him—

A young woman lays on the floor face down.

LUCAS (V.O.) (cont'd)
Shelby’s inanimate body.

4 INT. FINN'S APARTMENT - BEDROOM - 15 MINUTES EARLIER 4

The room is dimly lit by light filtering through horizontal blinds. An alarm blares mercilessly on a phone.

SOUND: ALARM BLARING (DULL, RELENTLESS)

FINN (20s) slaps the snooze button. Silence. He rolls onto his back, then sits up sharply.

FINN (V.O.)
Shit. Shelby.

He rubs his eyes, glancing at his nightstand clock: 9:01.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
I bet she didn’t leave by now. I better go check. She’s been upset, crying, something about a fight with her boyfriend Tim. I dropped her off at what I assumed was her place last night.

He stretches, his joints CRACKING loudly. He rolls out of bed, his feet hitting the cold hardwood floor with a soft THUD.

5 INT. FINN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS 5

Finn walks into the kitchen. He is still groggy. He turns on the COFFEE POT.

He glances into the living room. His eyes flick to the couch. SHELBY is sprawled out, passed out.

FINN (V.O.)
At first, I didn’t think much of it, but now that the fog of sleep is starting to lift, I realize something wasn’t right.
(MORE)

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Shelby never stays over unless she’s in trouble—or too drunk to go home.

Finn runs a hand over his face, sighing heavily.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
This is going to be one of those mornings.

He opens the fridge, pulling out eggs and a bag of stale bread.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Maybe if I make breakfast, things will feel normal again. Maybe we can talk.

He cracks the eggs into a bowl. The GNANING FEELING starts at the back of his head.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Something’s off.

As the eggs SIZZLE in the pan, Finn glances over at Shelby. She hasn’t moved. He watches for a moment, waiting for a stir, but she remains still.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Is she... asleep?

He tries to push the bad feeling away.

FINN
Breakfast? I’m making eggs. Want some?

No response. No movement.

FINN (cont'd)
Shelby? You good? You need a ride somewhere?

Still nothing.

Finn drops the SPATULA onto the counter—the sound is a sharp, nervous CLANG. His pulse races.

He takes a slow step toward the living room. His footsteps are heavy.

6 INT. FINN'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 6

He gets closer. Shelby hasn't moved an inch. Her body is limp, hair tangled across her face.

His heart skips a beat.

FINN
(Whispering)
Shelby?

He reaches out and gently brushes her hair aside, expecting her to stir. She doesn't.

FINN (V.O.)
Shit.

Panic surges through him. He crouches down beside her, his hand trembling. He presses two fingers to her neck, searching for a pulse.

He finds NOTHING.

FINN (V.O.) (cont'd)
My breath catches in my throat. My hands started to shake. This can’t be real. Shelby—Shelby—wasn’t supposed to end up like this.

A memory flashes: Shelby's tear-streaked face as she climbed into his car last night, her words about Tim.

Finn’s mind snaps. He shakes her by the shoulders.

FINN
Shelby? Come on, wake up. This isn’t funny.

His voice cracks, trembling with pure fear. She slips from the couch.

SOUND: An awful THUD as Shelby’s body hits the hardwood floor.

His stomach LURCHES. Shelby is face down, limbs twisted awkwardly.

FINN (V.O.)
My pulse pounding in my ears. I need to call someone. Call Lucas.

He scrambles for his phone, fumbling it in his shaking hands.

He stumbles back to the couch, collapsing onto it. He stares at Shelby's lifeless body on the floor, unable to move. He just sits there, breathing heavily, waiting for something to happen.

But nothing does.

7 INT. SHELBY'S BEDROOM - DAY - THE PAST DAY 7

Card: 26 hours ago

Shelby sleeps in her bed. Her alarm shows 7:00am.

8 INT. KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 8

The kitchen is a perfect reflection go domestic perfection, a dream kitchen, bright, alive, but silent.

Shelby (20s), dressed in seats, walks into the kitchen and glances to the living room.

Her mother, CAROL (50s), is sitting on the couch, illuminated by the morning light. Carol is staring intently at pictures resting on her lap.

Shelby heads straight to the counter. She pours a bowl of cereal, the rattling of the box and the milk fills in the silence.

Shelby looks at her mother.

SHELBY (O.S.)
She does this every day. Talks to him. More like at him. A picture of what he used to be. Happy. Satisfied. He stopped answering her calls.

Shelby puts the milk away and sits at the dining table and eats as quietly as she can. She stares into her cereal.

Carol's face presses softly onto the top of Shelby's head. Carol sits down beside her, a pile of loose photos still clutched in her hand.

CAROL
Do you remember? When you used to come home and jump around until I asked you about your day? You were always so- excited to tell me what yew had for lunch. Or what you got on a math test.
(MORE)

CAROL (cont'd)
(A slight crate in her voice)
Now-

Shelby stands up abruptly. The plastic bowl and spoon clang loudly on the table, the sound fills the room.

Shelby walks out of the kitchen. Carol is left alone, staring at the cereal bowl and the photos.

SHELBY (V.O.)
She’s a broken woman in her beautiful house, given to her by a broken man with the promise of loyalty. Now she is alone.

9 INT. SHELBY’S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 9

Shelby quickly packs a duffel bag. Clothes, shoes, a makeup bag.

SHELBY (V.O.)
I’ll head to Julia’s to get ready for the party. That way, I can get ready in peace. Not surrounded by the bad energy of this house.

She zips ch bag with decisive, harsh sound.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Don’t confuse my ignorance for selfishness. I feel pity for the woman. I don’t want to victim-blame. But the two of us don’t tach about it. She’ll defend him, like she always does. Why even try? What common ground could we find?

Shelby grabs her college ID, puts the lanyard around her neck. Bags in hand, she walks through the kitchen.

10 INT. SHELBY'S KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER 10

Carol breaks the silence.

CAROL
I work late tonight. I could leave you some of my-

SHELBY
(Quickly, interrupting)
No-no, I'll eat at school.

Shelby avoids eye contact, and squares her shoulders.

SHELBY (cont'd)
I'll text you what I eat?

Carol nods slowly, her eyes return to the stack of photos in her hands.

CAROL
Yeah... Yeah that would be nice.

Shelby steps out the door, pulling it shut quickly.

11 EXT. JULIA'S APARTMENT COMPLEX - MOMENTS LATER 11

The sky is a pale blue.

A worn, white compact car pulls into a reserved spot.Shelby puts the car in park and just sits, hands curled tight around the steering wheel.

SHELBY (V.O.)
This is my time to put it behind me. To pretend, just for a little while, that none of it exists.

She practices a smile and sprays perfume into the air, leaning into it.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
A reset button. Deep breath in. Deep breath out.

She pushes the car door open.

She reaches for the pack of cigarettes and puts them in her side pocket.

She holds them for a second.

She then pulls her hand back.

Backpack slung over one shoulder, she heads toward the apartment door.

SHELBY
(to herself)
Just in-case.

She pulls out a key from her pocket.

SHELBY (V.O.)
Julia and I have a deal. I get a key to her apartment, she gets to be my best friend.

She wraps her fingers tight around the lock cylinder. Pulling it out slowly so the tumblers don't make the loud CLICK.

She eases the door open, her foot catching the edge before it bangs the wall. She slips inside, closing the door behind her with painful care.

12 INT. CRUZ APARTMENT - ENTRYWAY - CONTINUOUS 12

She moves through the narrow, dimly lit hallway like a ghost. She knows the exact floorboards to step over.

She pauses at the small shoe cabinet.

SHELBY (V.O.)
That shoe cabinet is still here. Time hasn't moved the way it has everywhere else in here. The top is covered in faded marker scribbles. I hang my backpack, and move the shoe cabinet half an inch—the slight SCRAPE is our signal.

She takes a breath, letting the past and present settle inside her. She pushes off the wall and moves down the short hall to Julia’s room.

13 INT. JULIA'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 13

Shelby lands softly on the carpet, the familiar scent of lavender and books filling the air. Sunlight streams through the sheer curtains, spilling onto JULIA'S (20s) bed.

Julia is asleep, curled up, her chest rising and falling in slow, even breaths.

SHELBY (V.O.)
For a second, I just watch her, feeling that mix of comfort and distance. She looks peaceful, lost in sleep, but I can’t seem to feel the same peace.

Shelby steps lightly around the room. She glances at the neat desk—open notebooks, scattered makeup, the record player spinning softly in the corner.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I used to think these little details meant something. But today, it feels different. Like the more I look around, the more I realize how much I don’t know.

She walks to the window.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
She’s always been the one to make things seem simple. But right now, it’s like there’s a gap between us. And I don’t know how to close it.

She sits down on the edge of the bed. She reaches out and gently pushes a strand of hair off Julia’s face.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
My heart gives a little jolt, but I don’t pull my hand away. The familiar comfort of being with her hits me, but it’s also bittersweet. I can’t remember the last time I felt truly close to her.

She lets her hand drop to her lap.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I can’t shake the feeling that something’s changed. I want to reach out to her, but I don’t know if she’ll even understand.

Shelby stands up and walks back to the window.

SOUND: Julia stirs—a soft groan.

Shelby turns just as Julia rolls over, blinking awake. She looks up at Shelby, her face soft with sleep.

JULIA
Morning.

SHELBY
Morning.

Shelby manages a small smile that doesn't reach her eyes.

JULIA
(Yawning)
What time is it?

SHELBY
Late enough.

Shelby bites her lip.

SHELBY (V.O.)
I don’t know why I say it that way. The words feel out of place.

Julia pulls her blankets off and stands up.

JULIA
You still want to go to the party later?

SHELBY
(Quietly)
Yeah. Of course.

Julia glances at her, a small frown.

JULIA
You sure? You’re acting… I don’t know, different.

SHELBY
(Quickly)
Just tired. I didn’t sleep well.

JULIA
Alright. Well, I’m going to grab some breakfast. You coming?

SHELBY (V.O.)
I nod, even though I’m not sure I want to. I want to stay close to her, even if it feels like we’re miles apart.

INT. CRUZ APARTMENT - HALLWAY/KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Shelby follows Julia out of the room, walking a little slower. Julia navigates the house like she has her eyes closed, touching every wall.

They enter the kitchen. It’s warm, well-loved.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
The kitchen where we would have contests to see who could fill the most waffle ridges without the syrup touching. I once did forty-five. That record still stands.

Shelby sits down as Julia wakes up the COFFEE MAKER.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Growing up, Julia’s mom would give us milk with a little creamer and call it coffee. Now we’re somehow trusted with the real deal.

MR. CRUZ (50s) walks in.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I call him Dad. It feels normal, good. He is what I have. His heart is big enough for the six of us. He is a dad. At least what I understand a dad is.

Mr. Cruz fills up his mug. He glances at Shelby, noting the tightness in her shoulders, and then quietly walks out.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I think he noticed the look on my face and the way I melted into the chair as a sign that the space was a "girls’ only" zone right now.

Julia pours a mug of coffee and puts it under Shelby’s nose, then sits down.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Julia stares. She always does. She is good at this game. She will sit there until I am ready to talk.

Shelby looks down at the coffee.

SHELBY
My mom is waiting for a picture of food.

Shelby puts on a face of, Please don’t kill me.

Julia sighs and gets back up. She doesn't ask.

SHELBY (V.O.)
She doesn't even ask anymore. She knows what I want and how I like it. We simply know each other like that.

14 INT. CRUZ APARTMENT - JULIA'S BEDROOM - LATE AFTERNOON 14

The room is bathed in the golden, late-afternoon light. The air is thick with humidity and PERFUME.

SOUND: DISTANT HUM of a lawnmower. SOFT RATTLE of a ceiling fan. Muffled TV COMMERCIAL JINGLE from the living room.

SHELBY is stretched out on Julia’s bed, staring up at the fan blades as they blur together. Her stomach is visibly tight.

SHELBY (V.O.)
It’s been like this all day—a slow-building, unsettled feeling crawling up my spine, curling around my ribs.

JULIA walks past, barefoot, her bracelets JINGLING as she sets down a handful of jewelry on her dresser.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Everything about her is light. Effortless. Like getting dressed up for a party is second nature. Like tonight is just another night.

Julia sits at her vanity, leaning close to the mirror. She unscrews the cap to her eyeliner with practiced ease.

Shelby props herself up on her elbows, watching her reflection in the mirror.

Julia adjusts her eyeliner, wearing a dark green, silky dress. It clings perfectly.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
She looks like a million bucks. She knows it, too. Not in a way that’s obnoxious, just in the way Julia always knows things. She just gets it. Gets people. Gets everything.

Julia keeps flicking her gaze toward Shelby's reflection in the mirror. She subtly adjusts a dress strap that doesn't need adjusting.

Shelby sits up, legs crossed, scrolling through her phone, refusing to look at Julia.

SHELBY
You’re doing that thing again.

Julia raises an eyebrow in the mirror.

JULIA
What thing?

SHELBY
The thing where you stare at me like you’re waiting for me to confess to a crime.

Julia turns, leaning against her dresser, arms crossed.

JULIA
I just—

She pauses, the half-second hangs tight in the air.

JULIA (cont'd)
I don’t get why you’re even bringing Tim tonight.

Shelby's stomach twists. She grips her phone tighter, scrolling aimlessly.

SHELBY
(Throwing on a smirk)
Because it’s his party?

Julia exhales sharply, pushing off the dresser.

JULIA
Shelby. Come on.

Shelby’s thumb freezes on the screen. She forces a light, sharp laugh.

SHELBY
No, seriously, what the hell does that mean?

JULIA
You know what it means.

The weight of Julia’s voice hangs between them. Shelby presses the side button on her phone. The screen goes dark. Her own reflection stares back—jaw set, eyes glassy.

JULIA (cont'd)
He treats you like shit.

Her voice is quieter, steadier.

JULIA (cont'd)
And, honestly? He’s probably cheating on you.

The words hit Shelby like a physical blow. She sits rigid, jaw locked.

JULIA (cont'd)
(Turning away slightly)
Tell me I’m wrong.

Julia turns back. Her voice is lower, almost soft.

JULIA (cont'd)
Shelbs?

Shelby’s face goes hot. Her fingers curl into her palms, nails digging in.

SHELBY (V.O.)
She called me Shelbs. Why does it hurt?

Shelby's fingers curl into her palms, nails digging in.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Maybe because I’ve thought it too. Wondering if I’m just too stupid to know.

The room feels suddenly small. The perfume and setting spray are stifling.

SHELBY
(A strangled laugh)
You don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about.

She says it too fast. Julia tilts her head, watching carefully. She raises her hands in a gesture of peace.

JULIA
I’m saying this because I care about you.

SHELBY (V.O.)
The words should make me feel safe, but they don’t. They make me feel exposed.

Shelby smacks her knees as she is about to stand.

SHELBY
Yeah? Well, you have a funny way of showing it.

Shelby stands up too fast, head rush, dizziness. The room tilts for a second.

JULIA
Shel—

SHELBY
You know what? Don’t bother coming to the party. You’re uninvited.

Silence. Unapologetic silence.

SHELBY (V.O.)
I don’t mean it. I want her there, I need her there. But the words are already out.

Shelby doesn't wait to see the look of hurt or disappointment on Julia's face.

15 INT. CRUZ APARTMENT - HALLWAY/LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 15

Shelby bolts past the kitchen, past the living room where MR. CRUZ sits. The TV HUMS low.

Mr. Cruz glances up, eyebrows raised, but Shelby doesn't stop.

SHELBY (V.O.)
God, I want to go back, I want to take the words back. I can’t.

She takes the stairs two at a time, stomping hard.

SOUND: PICTURE FRAMES on the wall RATTLE as she passes.

She grabs the front door handle, WRENCHES it open, and steps outside.

16 EXT. CRUZ APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS 16

The air is thick with the late-afternoon heat, heavy and sticky.

Shelby stands on the porch. Her car is sitting in the driveway, bathed in golden sunlight.

She feels her pulse pounding in her throat, her wrists. Her hands are shaking.

SHELBY
(to herself)
It’s fine. I’m fine.

She walks toward her car.

SHELBY (cont'd)
I have a party to get to.

17 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - LATE AFTERNOON 17

SHELBY's white compact car roars down a street, the engine GROWLING. She takes a turn too fast, tires SQUEALING.

The windows are open, but the air is thick, warm, and sticky.

SHELBY (V.O.)
I don’t slow down. The air clings to my skin, my dress, the back of my neck. I can still smell Julia’s perfume on me. It makes my stomach turn.

Shelby STABS at the radio controls, skipping past multiple songs.

SOUND: Quick, choppy snippets of SLOW, SOFT MUSIC.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Skip. Skip. Skip.

LOUD, AGGRESSIVE MUSIC blasts.

SHELBY
Finally, something loud. Something that fills the space in my head.

She grips the wheel, her knuckles white.

SHELBY (V.O.)
My mind is still back there. In her room. With her voice in my ear—

JULIA (V.O.)
(echoing)
He treats you like shit. He’s probably cheating on you.

Shelby presses down harder on the gas.

SHELBY (V.O.)
She’s wrong. She has to be. Tim loves me. He tells me that all the time. The car hums beneath me, steady. A small comfort. At least it listens when I tell it what to do. At least it stays.

The car suddenly STUTTERS. A tiny hiccup beneath her foot.

She ignores it, pressing the gas harder. The engine COUGHS.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
Not now. Not now.

Another stutter. Her whole body tenses. The engine CHOKES out one last time—then DIES COMPLETELY.

The radio cuts out. The AC stops. The car coasts forward, then rolls to a dead stop at the side of the road.

SILENCE. It rushes in, deafening.

Shelby grips the wheel. The CHECK ENGINE LIGHT glares at her.

She presses her fingers against her temples and closes her eyes.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
This isn’t happening. No. This is Tim’s fault. If he had just picked up last night. If he had just made me feel like I mattered... I wouldn’t be stranded here, alone.

She presses her forehead against the wheel.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
But I love him. That means I have to trust him. Right?

She exhales slowly, pressing her forehead harder against the wheel. She reaches for her phone.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
He should be the one I call. Except... if I call him, he’ll say, "Jesus, Shelby, how the hell did you manage that?" He’ll make it my fault. And then he’ll take forever to show up.

Her jaw locks. She scrolls past Tim's name. She sees JULIA.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I should call her. I should apologize. But I picture myself sitting here, the call ringing and ringing, my own words echoing back at me, “You’re uninvited.”

She scrolls to FINN.

SHELBY (V.O.) (cont'd)
I shouldn’t. Because Finn sees through my bullshit. He always has. Because he’ll show up, without hesitation, and that terrifies me. If I call him, it’ll just prove everything I already know but can’t admit.

She presses CALL. The phone rings.

FINN (O.S.)
Shelbs?

Shelby almost hangs up. She presses her fingers to her temple instead.

FINN (O.S.) (cont'd)
Shelbsss—what’s wrong, pal?

SHELBY
(Flatly, barely audible)
My car’s dead.

Silence on the line for a beat. No jokes.

FINN (O.S.)
Where are you?

She gives him the street name.

FINN (O.S.) (cont'd)
Stay there. I’m coming.

The call CLICKS OFF.

The car is dark. The sky shifts to a golden evening light.

For the first time since leaving Julia’s, Shelby lets her head rest against the seat. She closes her eyes.

SHELBY
And I wait.

18 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - GOLDEN HOUR 18

FINN’s car SCREECHES to a stop beside SHELBY’s dead car. The golden, late-afternoon sun hits the scene.

Shelby is standing on the curb, having just ground out her cigarette beneath her heel. Her composure is brittle.

Finn jumps out. He sees the cigarette and his face subtly hardens.

FINN
I told you to stay in the car.

SHELBY
I needed air.

Finn walks over, his gaze fixed on the cigarette.

FINN
(Quietly)
You know how I feel about that.

Shelby looks at him, then takes one last, deep puff. She slowly grinds the cigarette out beneath her heel. The action is deliberate and heavy.

SHELBY
You don't know how big of a sacrifice this is right now.

Finn takes the duffel bag out of her back seat.

FINN
Okay. Get in. We'll call a tow truck for this later. You've got a party to get to.

Shelby slides into the passenger seat. Finn gets behind the wheel. The air is heavy with unspoken tension.

FINN (V.O.)
She called me. She could have called Tim. She could have called Julia. But she called me.

He pulls back onto the road.

19 INT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT 19

Shelby is peacefully asleep in the passenger seat. Finn's phone vibrates, indicating an incoming call. He glances at the caller ID and sees it's Lucas.

FINN
(whispering)
Hello.

LUCAS
(excited)
Hey, are you busy?

FINN
(glancing at Shelby)
Sort of.

LUCAS
(enthusiastically)
Well, my parents are out of town, 4 Brooklyn Styles on its way, and gaming night is a go. You want in?

FINN
(smiling)
Yeah, I'll see if I can make it. But hey, I have to go now.

20 INT. LUCAS'S BEDROOM 20

Lucas sits in his room, slightly disappointed, as Finn abruptly ends the call.

LUCAS
(disappointed)
Alright, catch you later then.

21 INT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT 21

Finn continues driving, stealing glances at Shelby as she begins to stir.

FINN
(teasingly)
Wakey wakey, Sleeping Beauty! I hope you're ready to face the world with your best bedhead hair.

Shelby looks out the window, realizing they're still on the road (Shelby full shot).

SHELBY
(confused)
Wait, are we there yet?

FINN
(laughing)
Nope, we've still got a ways to go. Don't worry, I'll make sure you're well-caffeinated before we arrive.

Finn, unable to contain his curiosity, leans in closer (close-up).

FINN (cont'd)
(sincerely)
Seriously though, what's the deal with this guy? First, it was his car, right? Now it's because he loves you "too much"? I'm not buying it, Sherlock.

Shelby looks out the car window, deep in thought (close-up).

FINN (cont'd)
Come on, spill the beans! Is he secretly a wizard or something? Does he brew a love potion every morning?

Shelby stumbles over her words, reluctant to admit the painful truth.

SHELBY
(whispering)
I don't know... he just... makes me feel... safe.

Finn is taken aback by her response (close-up).

FINN
(raising an eyebrow)
Safe, huh? Like a jail inmate? That's quite the relationship goals you've got there.

Finally, Shelby musters the courage to express what's been weighing on her heart.

SHELBY
(teary-eyed)
I'm scared, okay? I'm scared that if I leave him, he'll unleash his secret ninja skills on me. I've already lost my dad, and I'm not about to become a target for his hidden martial arts talents.

Silence envelops the car as they both struggle to find words (two-shot front).

The car pulls over to the side of the road.

Shelby remains teary-eyed, feeling vulnerable.

SHELBY (cont'd)
(softly)
Thanks anyway.

FINN
(whispering)
Tell you what, if you ever need a backup dancer to perform a dazzling exit, just give me a call. I'm always ready to break into spontaneous interpretive dance.

SOUND: RUSTLING LEAVES AND FOOTSTEPS

Shelby turns around, glancing back anxiously.

SHELBY
Someone’s coming. Go before they see you.

Finn puts the pedal to the metal, accelerating away.

22 EXT. TIM'S HOUSE - NIGHT - LATER 22

A massive house, lights spilling chaos and noise onto the lawn.

TIM (20s) pulls up in an expensive car. The engine GROWLS before he kills it. The sound of the party—BLARING MUSIC, SHOUTING LAUGHTER—hits him hard.

He slams the car door behind him and heads toward the front porch. His jaw is set.

TIM (V.O.)
I was here for Shelby. And I had a feeling this was about to blow up in my face.

TONY (20s), a large, tense figure, is standing by the door.

TIM
What is it?

TONY
Shelby’s upstairs, boss. In your room. She’s upset.

Tim's face tightens.

TIM
Why?

TONY
Saw Finn drop her off. Left right after. She didn’t even come in with anyone. Just went straight to your room.

Tim freezes. His gut twists.

TIM (V.O.)
Finn. Of course. That son of a bitch. He’d dropped her off at my house, like it was nothing.

The silence between the men is thick. Tim is careful, measuring his anger.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
Finn was a problem. He had no right to be anywhere near Shelby.

Tim turns abruptly from Tony and walks inside.

23 INT. TIM'S HOUSE - HALLWAY / STAIRCASE - CONTINUOUS 23

The party noise—laughter, music, glasses CLINKING—envelops him, but he filters it out.

TIM (V.O.)
All that mattered was what was waiting for him upstairs. Shelby. I hated seeing her upset, especially when I knew I was the one who caused it.

Tim takes the stairs two at a time, his anger mixing with a strange sense of helplessness.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
I didn’t want to control her. But every time I tried to let her breathe, I felt like I was losing her. And that thought—it scares the hell out of me.

He reaches the landing and heads toward his bedroom.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
I want her. I need her. I’ve given her the world, bought her nice things. But he wants my heart, and that I don’t know how to do.

He stops at his bedroom door.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
I know I can fix this. I’ve fixed it before.

24 INT. TIM'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 24

The room is dim. The muffled throb of the party comes from below.

Shelby is curled up on the bed, asleep. The soft rise and fall of her chest is visible.

Tim stands at the door for a long moment, watching her.

TIM (V.O.)
She looked so calm, so serene. I almost convinced myself that maybe this was enough. But I couldn’t. Not anymore.

Tim swallows, his throat tight. He walks into the room slowly.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
My mind kept circling the same question: how could I love someone so much and still lie to them, hurt them like this? I was too selfish to let her go.

He walks to the side of the bed.

TIM (V.O.) (cont'd)
If I really loved her, I'd let her go, right?

Shelby stirs, her eyes flutter open. For a second, she looks at him with softness, with trust.

Tim's voice cracks.

TIM
Shelby... I—I need to tell you something.

Shelby sits up slowly, confusion pulling at her features.

TIM (cont'd)
I've been lying to you. For a long time.

He takes a deep, shaky breath, his hands trembling.

TIM (cont'd)
I cheated on you, Shelby.

Her face freezes. The betrayal and hurt register instantly in her eyes.

TIM (cont'd)
I never meant for this to happen. I'm sorry. You deserve the truth. I've been keeping you here with lies. I've been holding on to you, and I don't know how to let you go.

The silence between them is suffocating.

TIM (cont'd)
I don't expect you to forgive me. But I needed you to know the truth. I couldn't keep lying to you, Shelby. Not anymore.

25 INT. LUCAS'S ROOM - NIGHT 25

Finn and Lucas are in Lucas's room, playing video games and talking.

A Finn’s phone rings

FINN
Hello?

TIM
I heard you gave my girl a ride to my party? Why are you picking up my girl?!

Finn gets aggravated.

FINN
Oh... uh, I don't know. She called me, and I just wanted to be a good friend, how about that?

Tim hangs up on him and Finn goes back to playing

The boys are watching a movie when Finn’s phone goes off again

Finn hesitates to answer when he sees its Shelby. He steps outside to answer the phone.

FINN (cont'd)
What do you want?

Shelby, holding back tears, speaks on the phone.

SHELBY
Hey, umm, can you pick me up?

FINN
What? Your boyfriend with a car can't drive you home? (close-up) Also, how the fuck did Tim get m-(full shot)

Shelby, with sadness in her voice, pleads.

SHELBY
Please, I need you.

Finn feels bad for her.

FINN
I'll be right there.

Finn hangs-up and goes back inside

Finn starts putting his coat on.

FINN (cont'd)
Sorry, man, Shelby needs me.

LUCAS
(annoyed)
Come on man. We still have like 2 whole pizzas left.

FINN
I'll be back it should be 2 hours max.

Finn grabs his keys

LUCAS
Okay, then I'll come with you, I want to see where Finn Adams is off to at these times.

FINN
Alright fine, but don't you dare touch the AUX.

Finn walks for the door, stops and turns to Lucas off camera.

FINN (cont'd)
I'll see you in the car.

26 INT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT 26

Finn is driving and Lucas is asking too many questions.

LUCAS
Why are you going? Who is this Shelby girl? Why would she ask you to come save her from some party?

FINN
She's an old friend.

LUCAS
An old friend?

FINN
Yeah, she's a middle school friend

LUCAS
That's why you want to save her.

FINN
I guess. I just want to be in her life again.

LUCAS
Alright, let's go get you "damsel in distress." Whoever the hell she is (close-up).

27 EXT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT \ INT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT 27

Finn and Lucas turn into the neighborhood

FINN
I'm going to call her.

Shelby is hiding in a bush, tears running down her face (mid-close-up).
Shelby's phone goes off.

UNKNOWN VOICE
Hey, I think she is over there!

Sound: RUNNING SHUFFLING

Shelby starts running and answers the phone.

SHELBY
Hey, um, just park down the street, alright?

Call ended

FINN
Was she crying?

LUCAS
Was she running? (close-ups)

Finn pulls over at the corner (full shot).

SEVERAL PAIRS OF FOOTSTEPS HEARD BEHIND SHELBY

Finn rolls down the window. (close-up)

LUCAS (cont'd)
Heyyy Shelby, Why are you here?

The boys eyes widen in fear as they look past Shelby

LUCAS (cont'd)
Oh shit get in!

Lucas opens the door and jumps to the back as shelby jumps into the passenger seat

28 INT. FINN'S CAR - NIGHT 28

Shelby is out of breath.

SHELBY
Drive!

Finn steps on the gas.

Lucas’s head springs from the back as he gets situated in the back

LUCAS
Who the fuck was that?

SHELBY
That... that is the friends of the jerk that just broke my heart in front of all those people.

She is drunk

SHELBY (cont'd)
Haha, the party was fun, though. Good dip chip.

LUCAS
Yeah, because that's what matters.

Shelby turns around to Lucas.

SHELBY
Noone likes a party pooper buddy.

FINN
Why were they chasing you?

SHELBY
I don't remember. They said something about having to get rid of me. I don’t know.

FINN
Basically, they were going to kill you?

LUCAS
That's deep. It's like a game.

SHELBY
Oh, oh, can we play?

Finn turns on music, and Shelby falls asleep

29 EXT. FINN'S HOUSE - NIGHT - LATER 29

FINN’s car pulls up and stops sharply in front of his house. The residential street is quiet, illuminated by the soft orange glow of the streetlights.

Finn quickly gets out and walks around the car. He opens Shelby’s door.

SHELBY is slumped in the seat. Her movements are sluggish, her eyes heavy.

FINN
Alright. Come on, Shelbs. We’re home.

Finn reaches for her, his concern clear. Shelby’s legs are unsteady. She tries to stand but stumbles heavily against the door frame.

Finn catches her, wrapping a strong arm around her waist and draping her arm over his shoulder. They begin the slow, labored walk toward the house.

SHELBY
(Slurred, a thick fog)
I'm not... Finn’s house. Tim’s party...

FINN
The party is over, trust me. Let’s just get inside.

They move slowly. Finn guides them down the sidewalk, his support unwavering.

SHELBY
(Teary, pleading)
Just let me sleep. Here.

FINN
Not here. We’re almost there. Just a few more steps.

Finn’s face is a mix of exhaustion and gentle determination. He realizes the fight is over; she just needs to collapse somewhere safe.

They finally reach the front door.

30 INT. FINN'S FOYER / LIVING ROOM - NIGHT 30

Finn fumbles the key in the lock while holding Shelby upright. He gets the door open and half-drags her inside.

SHELBY
(A faint, relieved smile)
Thank you, Finn.

FINN
Just breathe. You’re okay.

He guides her straight to the couch. She collapses onto it, curling up instantly.

31 INT. FINN'S LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS 31

The living room is dimly lit by a faint light spilling from the kitchen hallway.

Finn kneels, searching for a pulse, then lets out a long, heavy breath—relief. He gently pulls a loose throw blanket from the chair and covers her.

He stands for a moment, looking down at Shelby's face, now completely relaxed in sleep. He lets a fond, protective smile form on his face.

He reaches for the TV remote on the coffee table and powers the screen down. The room is now plunged into near darkness.

Finn quietly sits on the edge of the couch, his gaze fixed on her. He is utterly exhausted but unable to leave.

He reaches out a trembling hand and gently brushes a few strands of hair away from her face, his touch full of tenderness and affection.

After a long beat, Finn gets up slowly. He walks toward his bedroom, his steps soft and careful.

He closes the door to his room, a quiet, definitive CLICK.

32 INT. FINN'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - PRESENT TIME 32

A continuation of the first scene.

LUCAS
(A terrified whisper, barely audible)
Unbelievable...

Lucas steps into the room, movements slow, scanning Shelby’s body. His face is pale.

FINN
(A hollow rasp, no inflection)
Yeah.

Lucas’s gaze darts back to Finn, his face twisting from disbelief into a dark anger.

LUCAS
(Cutting, frustrated)
Jesus... How can you just leave her like this?

FINN
(A guilt-laced whisper, staring at his hands)
I’m not good with dead people, man.

LUCAS
(Wavering)
When did you first notice her?

FINN
(Exhaling shakily, forced clarity)
Man, I woke up to have breakfast and there she was. We didn’t go to bed together. And... she just died.

LUCAS
What do you mean ‘just died’? What are we going to do?

Lucas's voice rises, panic creeping in.

FINN
(Raw hopelessness)
I have no idea. That’s why I called you.

Lucas paces around the room, running a hand through his disheveled hair.

LUCAS
Right. Right. Does anyone else know about this?

FINN
Just you.

Lucas’s eyes narrow, looking back at Shelby, then back at Finn, as the weight of the situation sinks in.

FINN (cont'd)
(getting overwhelmed)
I mean fuck dude! Why did it have to be Tim’s girl?

Confusion turns to cold disbelief.

LUCAS
Tim’s girl? Gangster Tim?

FINN
(Sighing, rubbing his eyes)
Yeah, man. Her phone’s been ringing non-stop. He keeps calling.

Lucas's face drains of color. He is quiet for a long moment.

LUCAS
(Serious, low)
This is so serious.

Finn lowers his head again.

FINN
She’s already starting to go stiff, man. In case you wanted to wrap her up or something.

LUCAS
(Eyes widening)
How are we going to get her out of here? We have to wait until nighttime. Wait a minute! Tim is probably Geo-finding her phone.

FINN
(Heart racing)
What? You can do that?

LUCAS
We need to get rid of her phone right now.

FINN
Should we break it or flush it down the toilet?

LUCAS
(Shaking his head violently)
You don’t flush it down the toilet, man! We need to turn it off. Just switch off the GEO!

SHARP KNOCK from the front door. Both men freeze. Their eyes lock.

The knock comes again, louder, DEMANDING.

Lucas’s hands shake as he takes a step back.

LUCAS (cont'd)
(Barely a whisper)
Who the hell...?

Finn’s heart pounds. He slowly makes his way to the door.

33 INT. FINN'S APARTMENT - FOYER - CONTINUOUS 33

Finn opens the door. Two officers stand in the hallway: DETECTIVE HARRIS (40s, imposing) and OFFICER Sale (20s, young).

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Police. We’ve received a report about a missing person.

Finn’s blood runs cold. His throat is dry.

FINN
What... what do you want?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
I’m Detective Harris. We’ve received a report of a missing person—Shelby Peirce. Her mother reported her missing this morning. We have reason to believe she was last seen here.

FINN
(Mumbling, stunned)
Shelby’s not missing. She’s right here.

Detective Harris steps into the apartment. Officer Sale follows. They immediately see Shelby’s body on the floor.

Harris studies her for a long moment before shifting his gaze to Finn and Lucas.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
(Low, unyielding)
What happened to her?

Lucas, shaking with fear, is the first to break the silence.

LUCAS
We gave her a ride last night. She was at a party. She called us crying. She didn't want to be there anymore. We thought she just needed to get out. We didn't think this was going to happen.

Harris listens, his eyes narrowing.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
What about the bruises?

Lucas's face drains of color.

LUCAS
Bruises?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
(Icy)
On her neck. Can you explain that?

Finn's world crumbles. He hadn't noticed. The details crash back.

FINN
(Hoarsely)
I didn't hurt her. I swear.

Harris stares, calculating.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
We'll need both of you to come down to the station. We'll take your statements. And you need to come clean. All of it.

Finn nods numbly, trapped.
END OF THE NEWEST DRAFT!!! EVERYTHING PAST THIS IS THE WRITING OF A DEPRESSED 16 YEAR OLD!!! ALSO DOESN'T MAKE SENSE BECAUSE IT WAS WRITTEN BEFORE THE NOVEL, THAT FIXED A LOT OF THE PLOT HOLES, BUT I STILL! 6 YEARS LATER, DON'T HAVE A BETTER ENDING SO IT STAYS!

34 CARD 34

Dramatic music and text types in
"After the incident, Finn and Lucus were let go from a lack of evidence linking them to the crime"

INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - DAY

Detective Harris sits across from TIM LOPEZ, a young man with a frustrated expression.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Mr. Lopez, most things that happen around here have your name around it in some way. But... This one is a real step-up.

TIM
(ALREADY ANNOYED)
Why am I here? I had nothing to do with this.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Through some security cameras, it's shown that Shelby is running from what could only be assumed to be your house and getting into the car of Finn Wilson, a sophomore student of Greenleaf High.

TIM
So he did it. That's the night she was murdered, and she was found in his house.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
We don't think so. The tests we have run show no signs of it being him. As for you, the body shows signs of abuse, and her mother claims she would never hit her daughter. Mr. Wilson couldn't have done it as the bruises were just forming, 14 hours after your party.

TIM
You think I hit her?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
I'm not saying that. I just want you to explain the bruises that formed from hits during your party.

TIM
Maybe she just fell. Have you thought of that?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
15 times? Also, I'll note that there are no stairs in Shelby and Mr. Wilson's property.

TIM
(SOFTENING HIS VOICE)
Have you guys found the cause of death?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
(SEEING THAT HE HAS CALMED DOWN)
We believe it was due to brain damage. We found 10 bruises on the head itself. Mr. Wilson says that he got a call from Shelby, asking if he could pick her up. He also noted that she seemed to be crying.

TIM
I broke up with her, but I didn't hit her.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Well, somebody did. Can you think of anyone that could have done this?

TIM
Let me think. Chris was with us that night, but he was with us all last night.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Was there anyone that could have gotten her alone?

TIM
Well, Shelby got there around 10, but my best men were with her.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Wait, did you state she arrived at 10?

TIM
That was when I first saw her.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Mr. Wilson states he dropped Shelby off at your house around 9.

TIM
That can't be right. Shelby told me that dingbat dropped her off. I'm a busy man, you know?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
That had nothing to do with the case at foot. This isn't dating consulting, Mr. Lopez. That being said, Mr. Wilson told us about that call. He states it came around 30 minutes before dropping her off.

TIM
Then what happened during those 30 minutes?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
I couldn't tell you that. Can you?

TIM
What are you trying to say happened in that 30-minute period? I found out that Finn had dropped her off, that is that. Then I called him.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
So, you're telling me that I should just trust the town's "baddest boy on the block"?

Detective Harris continues speaking, but Tim's head is down, his expression grave.

35 INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - DAY 35

A compilation of the detective interviewing people of all types. As music plays in the background.

JUMP CUT TO:

36 INT. DETECTIVE'S OFFICE - DAY 36

Detective Harris sits at his desk, engrossed in his work.

A file slides into frame.

The person who slid the file is gone when Detective Harris looks up from his work.

The detective opens the envelope with "For Detective Harris's eyes only" written on it.

Inside is an index card with only two words of some kind of code.

The detective immediately starts decoding the message.

Montage of the detective trying to unscramble the message.

The tired detective puts his head down in his dark office, glancing at his keyboard.

[That's it!] He starts decoding the code with an expression of success on his face.

He writes and thinks at a million watts.

He leans back, taking in the chicken scratch of a message on the paper: Chris Anderson.

FADE TO:

37 INTERROGATION ROOM - LATER 37

CHRIS ANDERSON, a nervous young man, notices he is in a tight corner of the room.

Detective Harris enters.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
How are you doing?

CHRIS
Good.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Ok, so let's get right into this. Did you have any plans this weekend?

CHRIS
I didn't go out this weekend.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Oh? Really... ok.

The atmosphere in the room gets tense.

DETECTIVE HARRIS (cont'd)
I was told you were at a party on Saturday. Do you happen to know a girl named Shelby?

CHRIS
No, I do not.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
You know, I find that really hard to believe, considering that Shelby is Tim's girlfriend and all...

CHRIS
(INTERRUPTS NERVOUSLY)
Oh yeah, I knew that already. I knew that he was dating someone, but I didn't know they were at the party. I, erm...

DETECTIVE HARRIS
DO YOU KNOW WHAT TIME TIM ARRIVED AT THE PARTY?

CHRIS
10:00 pm.

Chris's breathing pattern changes.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
What activities did you guys do? Any drinking? Party games?

CHRIS
Oh no, definitely not drinking. Haha, we just sat around a fire, played a little soccer, and just talked a bit.

DETECTIVE HARRIS
What about food? Did you guys have pizza? Or sushi, maybe?

Chris's eyes widen, feeling as though a hole has formed through his chest. He chokes out the words.

CHRIS
Su-shi?

DETECTIVE HARRIS
Yeah, we found sushi in her system. We did the testing, and we found traces of poison in the sushi.
(MORE)

DETECTIVE HARRIS (cont'd)
We confirmed that the other party-goers did not have sushi at the party. So, why the special treatment?

Chris sits stunted in his thoughts.

THE END